Chapter 34

Life in New York:
Learning from International Peace Keeping

KIRAN SPENT TWO YEARS AT THE UNITED NATIONS. DURING THIS TIME, she travelled widely, read extensively, wrote regularly for various publications and interacted periodically with universities and other institutions. She also undertook speaking engagements (i.e., giving lectures at various fora). Despite her tight schedules, she found time to listen to audio books and spiritual music and to meditate daily.

Most importantly, she spoke to her father and daughter daily from whichever part of the world she happened to be in. She says that she has 'survived' because of the closeness to, and daily communication with, her family. She made full use of the marvels of information technology, especially the e-mail, to narrow the distance between her family and herself. Besides that, she kept herself in close contact with the goings-on back home in India via Zee TV, which she accessed through the cable, and the NDTV (New Delhi Television) channel, for which she subscribed through the Internet. She daily accessed many Indian newspapers online via the *Samachar* website.

Kiran took along a housekeeper. The UN system allowed this facility and she availed of it. Such support, she says, enabled her to do all that she wanted to:

> My objective was, now that I am away from home, why should I not use every minute of this 'exile by destiny' to do my maximum? Once I am back, I would never have this kind of uninterrupted time.

One of the many developments that took place during Kiran's absence from the Delhi scene was the stepping in of her daughter, Saina, and her life companion-to-be, Ruzbeh Bharucha, to oversee and creatively take forward the work of both her 'not-for-profit organizations': Navjyoti and India Vision Foundation. When Kiran left for the United Nations, her daughter was making television serials for the national channel, based on case studies from Kiran's book *What Went Wrong*. But as soon as she realized that her mother's work in India needed support, she offered to pitch in. As destiny would have it, at that point of time, the Navjyoti 'helm' needed closer and more careful steering. Decades of Kiran's efforts in the largest slum of Delhi were being literally demolished due to court orders for the relocation of the people staying there. Bulldozers were razing to the ground all structures, including the *gali* (street) schools run by Navjyoti. Saina took charge of Navjyoti. Because of her mobilizing capability and the support she received from the Navjyoti team, thousands of 'dislocated' children got their schools back, even if they were on the road and roofless, at the place where they were relocated. Kiran says that one of the biggest rewards of her UN assignment was the surfacing of the missionary spirit in her daughter. This spirit was invoked by her spiritual companion Ruzbeh